The Dreaded Batter Pudding Hurler

By Spike Milligan

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

USE ONLY

Suggested Roles
Actor 1: *Greenslade (narrator), Minnie Bannister, Seagoon*
Actor 2: *Henry Crun, Grytpype, Eccles, Moriarty*
SHARED: *FX (sound effects)*

GREENSLADE: **(Pg 25-42)** The English Channel 1941. Across the silent strip of green-grey water – in England – coastal towns were deserted, except for people. Despite the threat of invasion and the stringent blackout rules, elderly gentlefolk of Bexhill-on-Sea still took their evening constitutionals.

FX: *[Sea washing onto beach]*

HENRY CRUN: Ohhh, dear, dear, dear, ohh, it's quite windy on these cliffs, Minnie.

MINNIE BANNISTER: Yes, yes, what a nice summer evening, typical English evening.

HENRY CRUN: Mnk yes, the rain is lovely and warm. Minnie, I think I'll take one of my sou'westers off . . . hold my elephant gun.

MINNIE BANNISTER: Oh dear, I don't know what you brought it for, you can't shoot elephants in England you know!

HENRY CRUN: Mnk? Why not?

MINNIE BANNISTER: They're out of season.

HENRY CRUN: Oh. Does this mean we shall have to have pelican for dinner again?

MINNIE BANNISTER: I fear so, I fear so!

HENRY CRUN: Then I'll risk it. I'll shoot an elephant out of season.

GREENSLADE: Listeners who are listening will, of course, realize that Minnie and Henry are talking rubbish; as erudite people will realize, there are no elephants in Sussex. They're only

found in Kent. North of a line drawn between two points thus making it the shortest distance.

HENRY CRUN: . . . Well, if that's how it is, I can't shoot any.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *You thought you were safe.*
ACTOR 2: *You thought you could hide.*
ACTOR 1: *You thought that you didn't really need to use the restroom before the performance . . . but now you're questioning that decision.*
ACTOR 2: *Now from the inner-most recesses of the BBC radio vaults and the creative minds of Spike Milligan, Peter Sellers*
ACTOR 1: *And a short, fat, little guy whose name is Harry Secomb, but who I prefer to lovingly call "Tubby" comes one of the famed Goon Show scripts.*
ACTOR 2: *The Dreaded Batter Pudding Hurler*
ACTOR 1: *Created by Spike Milligan, Peter Sellers and "Tubby"*
ACTOR 2: *Also known as Harry Secomb.*

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MINNIE BANNISTER: Come Henry, we'd better be getting home.

FX: *[Metal door slides open]*

HENRY CRUN: Minnie, did you hear a gas oven door slam just then?

MINNIE BANNISTER: Don't be silly, Henry! Who'd be walking around these cliffs with a gas oven?

HENRY CRUN: Lady Docker?

MINNIE BANNISTER: Yes, but apart from the obvious ones, who'd want to . . .

FX: *[Whoosh! Splat!]* (*Minnie is hit from behind and crumples in a heap)*

MINNIE BANNISTER: Help Henry! I've been struck down from behind, buddy. Heelp!

HENRY CRUN: Mnk - oh dear dear! Poor Minnie! Police! English Police! Law Guardians. . .

FX: *[Police whistle]*

SEAGOON: Can I help you, sir?

HENRY CRUN: Are you a policeman?

SEAGOON: No, I'm a constable.

HENRY CRUN: Oh, what is the difference?

SEAGOON: They're spelt differently. What's happened to this dear old silver bearded lady?

HENRY CRUN: She was struck down from behind.

SEAGOON: And not a moment too soon. Congratulations, sir.

HENRY CRUN: I didn't do it.

SEAGOON: Coward. . . Now tell me, who did this felonious deed. What's happened to her?

HENRY CRUN: It's much too dark to see, strike a light.

SEAGOON: Not allowed in blackout. We daren't. Why, only twenty-eight miles across the Channel the Germans are watching this coast. *[to audience]* We tried using a candle, but it wasn't very bright and we daren't light it, so we waited for dawn, and there, in the light of the morning sun, we saw what had struck Miss Bannister. It was . . . A batter pudding!

FX: *[Dramatic chord]*

SEAGOON: Well, get her off this cliff, it's dangerous. Meantime, I must report this to the Inspector. I'll call on you later, goodbye. *[to audience]* That night I lay awake in my air-conditioned dustbin thinking; now who on earth would want to strike another with a batter pudding? Obviously it wouldn't happen again, so I fell asleep. Nothing much happened that night, except that I was struck with a batter pudding.

GREENSLADE: In the months to come, thirty-eight batter puddings were hurled at Miss Bannister. A madman was at large, Scotland Yard was called in.

GRYTPYPE: Inspector Seagoon, my name is Hercules Grytpype-Thynne, Special Investigation. This Batter Pudding Hurler... He's made a fool of the police.

SEAGOON: I disagree, we were fools long before he came along.

GRYTPYPE: You silly twisted boy. Nevertheless, he's got to be stopped, now Seagoon . . . these batter puddings, they were obviously thrown by hand.

SEAGOON: Not necessarily. Some people are pretty clever with their feet.

GRYTPYPE: *[with a strange look at Seagoon]* Now, Seagoon, these batter puddings, were they all identical.

SEAGOON: All except the last one. Inside it, we found this . . .

GRYTPYPE: What? An army boot!? So the dreaded hurler is a military man. Any troops in the town?

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SEAGOON: The fifty-sixth Heavy Underwater Artillery.

GRYTPYPE: Get there at once, arrest the first soldier you see wearing one boot. Off you go!

FX: *[Transition music – Should be somewhat recognizable military music]*

SEAGOON: Major Bloodnok, *[salute]* I must ask you to parade your men. I'm looking for a criminal.

BLOODNOK: You find your own, it took me years to get this lot! *[pause to contemplate the situation]* Very well then, Bugler Max Geldray? Sound fall in the hard way.

FX: *[Musical interlude: 'They Were Doing The Mambo']*

(see* http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kwDL-Bp8yP8 *for music as troops assemble)*

BLOODNOK: Silence, silence lads, silence! I'm sorry I had to get you out of bed in the middle of the day, but I'll see you get extra pay for this, I promise you. Now, Seagoon, which is the man?

SEAGOON: I walked among the ranks looking for the soldier with one boot, but my luck was out, the entire regiment were barefooted.

ECCLES: We want our beddy byes.

SEAGOON: Who are you?

ECCLES: Lance Private Eccles, sir.

SEAGOON: *[to audience]* I inspected the man closely, he was the nearest thing I'd seen to a human being, without actually being one. At last, by the light of a passing glue factory, I saw that Eccles was only wearing, one boot!

ECCLES: Well, I only got one boot.

SEAGOON: I know, but why are you wearing it on your head?

ECCLES: Why? Why? It fits, dat's why! What a silly question to ask . . .

SEAGOON: Let me see that boot! *[to audience]* Mmmmm, size nineteen . . . *[to Eccles]* What size head have you got?

ECCLES: Size nineteen.

SEAGOON: Curses, the man's defense was perfect. Major Blooknok? Where's this man's other boot?

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BLOODNOK: Stolen.

SEAGOON: By whom?

BLOODNOK: A thief.

SEAGOON: You sure it wasn't a pickpocket?

BLOODNOK: Positive, Eccles never keeps his boots in his pocket.

SEAGOON: *[to audience]* Damn! They all had a watertight alibi. Months went by; I couldn't stop them. Still no sign of the Dreaded Hurler. Finally I walked the streets of Bexhill at night disguised as a human man. Then suddenly...

FX: *[A sinister and dramatic fanfare]*

SEAGOON: . . . Nothing happened. But it happened suddenly mark you.

MORIARTY: Pardon me, my friend.

SEAGOON: *[to audience]* I turned to see the speaker. He was a tall man wearing sensible feet, and a head to match. He was dressed in the full white outfit of a Savoy chef. Around his waist were tied several thousand cooking instruments. And behind him he pulled a portable gas stove from which issued forth the smell of batter pudding.

MORIARTY: Could I borrow a match? You see my gas has gone out and my batter pudding was just about to start browning.

SEAGOON: Certainly, here . . . No, no, no . . . Keep the whole box, I have another match at home.

MORIARTY: So rich! Well, thank you m'sieur, you have saved my batter pudding from getting cold. As you'll agree there's nothing quite so bad as being struck down with a cold batter pudding. Well, good night.

SEAGOON: I watched the strange man as he pulled his gas stove away into the darkness. But I couldn't waste time watching him, my job was to find the Dreaded Batter Pudding Hurler!

GREENSLADE: Those who think that Seagoon is not cut out to be a detective, please write to him care of Rowton House.

SEAGOON: *[to audience]* On December 25th the Hurler changed his tactics. That day Miss Bannister was struck with a Christmas Pudding.

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GRYTPYPE: *[reading a letter]* A Miss Bannister has just received this letter. It was postmarked 'Africa', and inside was a portion of batter pudding.

SEAGOON: So he's in Africa, now we've got him cornered. I must leave at once.

GREENSLADE: Seagoon travelled by sea. To avoid detection by enemy U-boats he spoke German throughout the voyage and was heavily disguised as a Spaniard.

SEAGOON: *[to audience]* The ship was disguised as a train, to make the train sea-worthy it was done up to look like a boat and painted to appear like a tram. Also on board were Major Bloodnok and his regiment. When we were ten miles from Algiers, we heard a dreaded cry.

ECCLES: Mine ahead woohoowoo! Dirty big mine ahead!

FX: *[Explosion]*

SEAGOON: Bloodnok and I floundered in the cruel sea.

FX: *[Lapping waves]*

BLOODNOK: Fortunately, we found a passing lifeboat and dragged ourselves aboard.

SEAGOON: We had no oars, but luckily we found two outboard motors and we rowed with them. For thirty days we drifted to and fro, then hunger came upon us.

BLOODNOK: Aeioughhhhh, if I don't eat soon I'll die of hunger, and if I die I won't eat soon. Wait a moment, *[sniffs]* ohohohh, can I smell cooking or do my ears deceive me?

SEAGOON: He was right, something was cooking. There, in the other end of the lifeboat was. . . a gas stove! Could this be the end of our search?

BLOODNOK: I'll knock on the oven door.

FX: *[Knocking on metal]*

MORIARTY: *[Faintly]* Just a minute please, I'm in ze bath...

FX: *[Door scrapes open]*

SEAGOON: Don't move, I arrest you as the Dreaded Batter Pudding Hurler.

MORIARTY: Sacre Bleu!

SEAGOON: Hands up, you devil, don't move! This finger is loaded.

MORIARTY: If you kill me, I promise you, you'll never take me alive.

BLOODNOK: Wait, how can we prove he's the hurler?

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SEAGOON: That batter pudding in the corner of the stove is all the evidence we need. We've got him!

FX: *[Dramatic fanfare]*

GREENSLADE: But it wasn't so easy. Forty days they drifted in an open boat.

FX: *[Lapping waves]*

BLOODNOK: Oooaeioughhhh, I tell you Seagoon, let's eat the batter pudding or we'll starve!

SEAGOON: No, yer hear me, No! That's the only evidence we've got.

BLOODNOK: We must eat it or die.

SEAGOON: Never!

GREENSLADE: And that, we fear, is the end of our story, except of course, for the end. Should Seagoon eat the batter pudding and live, or leave it and in the cause of justice, die? Send your suggestions on a piece of batter pudding.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Spike Milligan
Book: The Goon Show Scripts, Pgs 25-42
ISBN: 978-0722160794
Publisher: Sphere Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1973

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier